Rash

By Eric Bogosian

Man speaks directly to the audience, gesticulating with a large barbecue fork as he mimes grilling at a barbecue.

INTRODUCTION

Two types of people exist in today's society: Type One is the put-upon, guilt- ridden, half-liberated white American middle-class individual and Type Two is everyone who preys upon Type One. In Rash from Pounding Nail into the Floor with my Forehead, Eric Bogosian plunges us into the world of the self-interested living in today's "SUBURBIA"... where the affluent escape from the perils of the urban jungle. You may not like the character you meet, but you've certainly seen him around before and no matter how detestable, unfortunately, there is a little of us in each of them. Rash by Eric Bogosian

So what we did, we put a chain-link fence around the whole fifteen acres. Barbed wire on top. For security, for security. 'Cause you know, Charlie, we're here all summer, the kids are running around in the yard. I sleep better at night just knowing it's out there.

Oh, yeah, we're here all summer. I go down the city maybe two, three times a month. But you know it's hot down there and we got everything we need up here. The pool. Sonia's got her tennis court, I got my griller. I just stay here all summer and grill. I put everything on this thing: steaks, chops, chicken. Last Sunday, I did some lobsters. Came out beautiful. Once they stop moving, they're a snap to cook.

Did you look at my grill, Charlie? Look at my grill. Brand new, I just got it. It's beautiful. See, right here where the steaks are, this is the grilling part. Then over here I got two stovetops, you wanna boil some peas, carrots. Underneath, oven. You-can bake a cake, cookies, whatever you want.

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Up here, microwave oven. Ice chest on the side, 'frigerator on the back. Three phone lines.

Very reasonable, around three grand. Got it from the Hammacher-Schlemmer catalog. I love it. I just stand here all summer and grill. Very relaxing, I just stay here by the pool, they *swim' I* grill. Makes me very mellow. Like meditating.

(Shouts WHAT?!! Nah, we don't want any . . . You want any goat cheese? Charlie doesn't want any either. I don't care what you did to it, we *hate* goat cheese. Listen, Honey, we're starving to death out here, send out some Doritos or something. Well, if you're too busy, Jeremy can bring 'em.

(Calling to a different part of the stage) Jeremy, Honey, go up to Mommy on the porch, get Daddy and Uncle Charlie some Doritos.

(Back to Sonia) He can do it, Sonia, just give him the Doritos. Give him the Doritos! Don't give him the goat cheese!

(To Charlie) Oh yeah, he loves it. He's in there all day. Like a fish. No. No. No. No. There's no chlorine in that pool, Charlie. They use chlorine in the *cheap* pools. This filter, this is the *best* you can get. Fourteen layers of charcoal, three layers of sand. Then there's a machine, you can't see it, under the tennis courts, boils the water into steam, sterilizes it drop by drop.

Comes back to the pool, completely pure. Completely pure. You can't get water like that in *nature.* 'Cause I figure we got people comin' over every weekend. Somebody's gonna come over, do a couple of laps. Guy's got herpes, next thing I know everybody in the house has herpes. What do you do with a six year old with herpes? I figure spend the money, get the filter. Why waste the aggravation?

I got a good life. I never want to leave the house. I had to go to the city last week, visit a client, it was *torture.* It was like going off to war.

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I mean you go down there now, it's like the black hole of Calcutta. You been down there lately? It's depressing. They're lying on the streets, begging, on drugs. With the babies, now they're begging. I feel so bad for those poor people, 'cause it's not their fault.

But what can you say? Life isn't fair. It's the roll of the dice. I didn't make up the rules. I just say thank God he loves us. *(Fiddles with the cooking steaks)*

You like roast peppers? *(Stabs downward, then holds the fork up)* Look at this pepper, isn't it beautiful? Balducci's, five bucks each, the best you can get. I'll have one too.

See, I keep 'em on ice over here in the ice chest, anytime I want peppers, I . . . WHAT? YES! PUT THE CORN ON *NOW*. PUT THE CORN ON NOW, SONIA! THE STEAK'S GONNA BE READY IN FIVE MINUTES. YOU WANT COLD STEAK? I'M ASKING, YOU WANT COLD STEAK? THEN PUT THE CORN ON NOW!

Did I tell you about last spring when we went on vacation? No, I know you know we went on vacation, but let me tell you. . .

About three weeks before we go away, I'm working in mid-town around 48th Street. And every day, I go out to lunch, stretch my legs. And every day there's this guy in front of the building with one of those signs: WILL WORK FOR FOOD. Begging. So every day, I pass this guy, I give him a quarter, I figure, I can afford it.

The guy gets used to seeing me. Every day at lunch, sees me coming, kinda gets all perky when he sees me. Gets up on his hind legs.

So about a week before we're gonna go on vacation, I go out to lunch, I see the guy, guy sees me, I reach into my pocket, I don't have any change! He's looking at me. So I figure, what the hell, who's it gonna kill? Give the guy a buck.

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I throw a buck at the guy. Turns out, it's not a buck, it's a twenty dollar bill. Don't ask me how it happened. Guy jumps up, starts shaking my hand, blessing me, telling me God loves me, Jesus loves me. Shaking my hand in the middle of the sidewalk. And I never really looked at this guy up close before. He's got all these sores all over his face, no teeth, his breath could peel paint. And I'm thinking, you know, "I gave you the money, now go back and sit down!"

Anyway, I forget about the guy; three days later, me and Sonia go down to St. Barth's. . . Very nice hotel by the beach, they give you a brochure about the food and how there's these dolphins and you lie on the beach and watch the dolphins. Seven hundred dollars a night.

We get down there, I'm a little tense, I want to relax, so we go down the beach. I'm lying there, looking for the dolphins, no dolphins. I'm getting a strain in my neck. Turns out, there's no dolphins in the Caribbean. I'm in litigation with the hotel as we speak.

Anyway, we're lying there, Sonia says, "What's that?" She's pointing to my hand. There's this rash on the back of my hand. I say, I don't know, poison ivy from the country house. Forget about it.

Charlie, by the end of the week, this rash is halfway up my arm. We come back to the city, I go straight to my doctor's.

He says, "Good thing you came to see me. If you hadn't come to see me, that would have gone right up your arm, up your neck, into your eyes. You'd be *blind!*" Turns out. . . RIGHT! THAT'S RIGHT! The *guy*. Turns out, it's some kind of disease they give each other in the men's shelter. Some kind of bum disease.

All I'm saying, Charlie, all I'm saying is: I give the guy money, he gives me a disease!

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(Looks up) Jeremy, what are doing?! No, Honey, don't throw Doritos in the pool. Get away from the pool, YOU'RE GONNA CLOG UP THE FILTER, IT'S GONNA COST ME FIFTY THOUSAND DOLLARS, NOW GET AWAY FROM THE POOL. JUST GO SOMEWHERE.

(Back to Charlie) I mean, look, I'm the world's biggest liberal. But you know I'm watching that CNN, I'm watching those riots in L.A. and I'm thinking to myself, What if they start doing that around here? What if they start running around like that around here?

I mean, look at this house, Charlie. You can't see this house from the road. We're vulnerable up here. What happens, we're up here one Sunday, we're hanging out: reading the paper, eating bagels, grinding coffee beans. I pick up the phone to call my mother, "Oh, the phone is dead!"

I look up, a couple of homies are at the back door. Breaking down the back door. They don't even have to be black, they could be anybody. Then what do I do? What do I do then? "Oh, come on in, would you like a cup of coffee? Maybe you'd like to rape my wife, kill my kids, burn my house down?"

What do I do then, Charlie? What do I do then?

That's why I have the gun. *(Fiddles with steak)* I would, I would shoot them, for the kids I would shoot. If they were from the phone company, I would still shoot them.

Anyways, these are ready. *(Calls off)* Jeremy, Honey, come out of the bushes, Daddy's not angry anymore. Come on out, we'll discuss it later. We're gonna have din-din now. No, no hot dogs, we've got fifteen dollar-a-pound prime sirloin from Dean & DeLuca, now come out of the bush. COME ON! COME IN THE HOUSE!

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